Trip plan

Generated: 9 November 2026 | **Trip**: South Island self-drive, Christchurch (CHC) to Queenstown (ZQN), Sat 6 Mar to Sun 14 Mar 2027 (8 nights) | **Travellers**: 2 adults, 1 driver

Results

1. The trip at a glance

The route is a one-way loop that takes in the three alpine areas that match your interests. On the way it goes over Arthur's Pass, down the West Coast glaciers, over Haast Pass to the lakes, and to Aoraki/Mount Cook and Lake Tekapo, then on to Queenstown and Milford Sound by road. Each driving day stays under 500 km. The car is never moving before sunrise or after sunset. There are no boats or ferries, beaches, or walks longer than 2 hours. Five of the eight nights are in Accor hotels.

Day	Date	Route	Drive (approx.)	Highlights	Overnight
1	Sat 6 Mar	CHC Airport, Willowbank, Port Hills, CHC Airport	50 km, 1 h 10	Kiwi and kea at Willowbank; views of the Southern Alps from the Port Hills	Christchurch (Accor)
2	Sun 7 Mar	Christchurch to Franz Josef via Arthur's Pass	443 km, 6 h 00	Castle Hill, Devil's Punchbowl Falls, kea at Otira Viaduct, Hokitika Gorge, Lake Mapourika	Franz Josef
3	Mon 8 Mar	Glacier day, based in Franz Josef	90 km, 1 h 30	Franz Josef Glacier valley, West Coast Wildlife Centre (kiwi), Fox Glacier viewpoint, Lake Matheson	Franz Josef
4	Tue 9 Mar	Franz Josef to Wānaka via Haast Pass	300 km, 4 h 00	Knights Point, Haast Pass waterfalls, Blue Pools, The Neck lookout, Mt Iron	Wānaka (Accor)
5	Wed 10 Mar	Wānaka to Lake Tekapo via Aoraki/Mt Cook	331 km, 4 h 15	Lindis Pass, Hooker Valley or Kea Point, Tasman Glacier view, Peter's Lookout, Dark Sky stargazing	Lake Tekapo (Accor)
6	Thu 11 Mar	Lake Tekapo to Queenstown	295 km, 3 h 45	Mt John summit, Clay Cliffs, Kawarau Gorge, Kiwi Park, Skyline Gondola	Queenstown (Accor)
7	Fri 12 Mar	Queenstown to Milford Sound to Te Anau (by road only)	412 km, 5 h 45	Mirror Lakes, Lake Gunn, kea at Monkey Creek, Homer Tunnel, Milford foreshore, takahē	Te Anau
8	Sat 13 Mar	Te Anau to Queenstown, Glenorchy and Arrowtown	335 km, 4 h 45	Bennett's Bluff, Glenorchy lagoon, Arrowtown, Crown Range lookout	Queenstown (Accor)
9	Sun 14 Mar	Hotel to ZQN Airport	10 km, 15 min	No sightseeing. Refuel, return the car, fly at 11:00.	(depart)

Total about 2,270 km and about 31 hours of driving. The longest days are Day 2 (443 km) and Day 7 (412 km). Distances and times are planning estimates for a car in summer conditions without stops. Check each one in Google Maps or the NZTA journey planner before you go.

2. How your constraints were applied

Your rule	How the plan handles it	Status
At most 500 km in any day	Maximum is 443 km (Day 2). Even the backup routes (Section 6) stay under 500 km or add an overnight stop.	**Met**

Never drive after dark	Sunset is between 20:07 and 20:19 on this trip, and sunrise between 07:14 and 07:41 (table in Section 4). Every day has the car parked at least 60 minutes before sunset. No departure is before sunrise. Stargazing at Tekapo is on foot or by the operator's coach.	**Met**
No boats or ferries	None in the plan. The following are deliberately left out: the Milford Sound cruise, the TSS Earnslaw on Lake Wakatipu, the Te Anau glowworm caves (reached by boat), jet boats, and the Kaikōura whale-watch boat. Milford Sound is seen from the road and the foreshore walk.	**Met**
No beaches	The coastal stops (Hokitika beach, Ship Creek, Gillespies Beach) are skipped. Knights Point is a clifftop lookout from the car park. Lake stops are viewpoints and lakeside paths, not beaches.	**Met**
Walks no longer than about 2 h	Every walk is 2 h return or less (each one is timed below). The following are left out as too long: the full Hooker Valley Track (about 3 h), Roys Peak, Ben Lomond, Key Summit and Lake Marian.	**Met**
See as much as possible, early starts fine	Each day starts at or just after sunrise and has 4 to 8 named stops.	**Met**
Interests: mountains and lookouts, lakes, glaciers, wildlife	Three alpine areas (Arthur's Pass, Aoraki/Mt Cook, Fiordland), at least 9 lakes, 2 glacier valleys plus the Tasman Glacier, and wildlife on 6 of the 8 full days: kiwi, kea, takahē and possibly fur seals.	**Met**
Last day: no sightseeing	Day 9 is refuel, car return and check-in only.	**Met**
Accor wherever possible, twin beds, up to NZ$300	5 of 8 nights are Accor (Christchurch, Wānaka, Tekapo and two in Queenstown). As far as I could find, Accor has no hotel in Franz Josef or Te Anau, so good independent hotels are suggested there. Book a room with 2 beds. March rates must be checked against the NZ$300 limit, and lower-priced fallbacks are listed.	Check rates when booking
One driver	No day has more than about 2 h of driving without a stop. The two long days are spaced apart (Days 2 and 7), and each is followed by a shorter driving day.	**Met**

3. Why this route (routing decisions)

- **West Coast first, then the lakes.** Arthur's Pass is the only way to reach the glaciers from Christchurch in one day under 500 km, and it is a highlight in its own right (mountains and kea). Going south down the coast means Haast Pass is never driven twice.
- **Two nights in Franz Josef.** The West Coast gets a lot of rain. Two nights give a full day to see the glaciers in the best weather window. They also mean one less hotel change and a backup morning if Day 3 is clouded in.
- **Aoraki/Mt Cook from Wānaka, sleeping at Tekapo.** Mt Cook Village has no Accor hotel, and accommodation there costs more than your budget. Tekapo has two Accor hotels and is inside a Dark Sky Reserve. The **new moon is around 8 March 2027**, so the sky on the night of 10 March should be very dark, which is ideal for stargazing.
- **Milford Sound by road, not by cruise.** The Milford Road is one of New Zealand's great mountain drives, and all the best sights are roadside or short walks. Queenstown to Milford and back is 580 km in one day, which is over your limit. So Day 7 ends in Te Anau (412 km), and Day 8 goes back to Queenstown.
- **Two Queenstown nights split around Te Anau.** This gives one more Accor night than staying two nights in Te Anau, and makes the final morning a 10-minute drive to the airport.
- **Not included:** Kaikōura (wildlife there is mostly seen by boat, and it would add a day), Dunedin and the Catlins (coastal and beach-focused), and Abel Tasman (boat or beach based). These suit your avoid list poorly or don't fit 8 nights.

4. Daylight table (your driving window)

Calculated for the place where each day's driving starts and ends, in NZ Daylight Time (UTC+13). In deep valleys such as Milford and Franz Josef the sun drops behind the mountains earlier, so treat sunset as the absolute latest time to be parked, not a target.

Date	Place	Sunrise	Sunset	Planned first departure	Planned arrival at hotel	Margin before sunset
Sat 6 Mar	Christchurch	07:14	20:09	about 15:45 (car pick-up)	19:00	1 h 09
Sun 7 Mar	Christchurch to Franz Josef	07:16	20:17	07:20	17:30	2 h 45
Mon 8 Mar	Franz Josef	07:26	20:15	07:45	18:50	1 h 25
Tue 9 Mar	Franz Josef to Wānaka	07:28	20:18	07:40	15:30 (then a local loop until 19:00)	1 h 15 (after local loop)
Wed 10 Mar	Wānaka to Tekapo	07:32	20:11	07:40	17:20	2 h 51
Thu 11 Mar	Tekapo to Queenstown	07:29	20:17	08:00	15:30 (afternoon on foot)	4 h 45
Fri 12 Mar	Queenstown, Milford, Te Anau	07:37	20:19	07:45	18:45	1 h 34
Sat 13 Mar	Te Anau to Queenstown	07:41	20:13	07:50	17:15	2 h 58
Sun 14 Mar	Queenstown	07:39	(not driving)	07:50	Car returned by 08:20	n/a

Day-by-day itinerary

Times are targets, not appointments. Each day has a **buffer** (free time for spontaneous stops, photos and coffee) and a **latest leave time**. If you are behind schedule at that time, drop the stops marked *optional* and drive on.

Day 1: Sat 6 Mar. Arrive Christchurch, wildlife and Port Hills views

50 km | about 1 h 10 driving | Sunset 20:09

Time	Plan
14:30	Land at CHC. Allow 45 to 75 minutes for immigration, bags and biosecurity (declare any food, hiking boots and outdoor gear).
15:45	Collect the one-way rental car at the airport. Inspect it and photograph any damage. Set the navigation and check that the fuel tank is full.
16:00 to 17:15	**Willowbank Wildlife Reserve** (6 km, 10 min). Kiwi in the nocturnal house, kea, takahē and other native birds. *Check opening hours before you travel.* Sources disagree between 17:00 and 19:00 closing in summer, with last entry possibly 16:00. If you will arrive after last entry, swap it for the International Antarctic Centre beside the airport (little blue penguins) and check its hours too.
17:40 to 18:30	**Port Hills Summit Road lookouts** (about 22 km, 30 min). Sign of the Kiwi and the Summit Road give views over Christchurch and the Canterbury Plains to the Southern Alps, and down into Lyttelton Harbour. You see the harbour from above and never go near the water.
18:30 to 19:00	Drive to the hotel (about 22 km). Arrive by 19:00, which is 69 min before sunset. Buy water, snacks and Day 2 breakfast at the airport shops on arrival, or at a supermarket on the way to Willowbank. Dinner at or near the hotel.

Overnight: Novotel Christchurch Airport (Accor; it sits next to the terminal, so the Day 2 start is 15 minutes quicker than from the city). **Buffer:** skip the Port Hills if arrival runs late. It's a nice extra, not essential.

Day 2: Sun 7 Mar. Christchurch to Franz Josef over Arthur's Pass

443 km | about 6 h 00 driving | Sunset 20:17 at Franz Josef | Longest day

Time	Stop	Drive to here	Time there
07:20	Depart (sunrise 07:16). Breakfast is the pre-bought snacks or the hotel breakfast if it opens by 06:30.	n/a	n/a
08:30	**Castle Hill / Kura Tāwhiti**. Giant limestone boulders, a 20 to 30 min easy walk.	95 km, 1 h 10	30 min
09:40	**Arthur's Pass village**. Visitor centre, toilets, coffee. **Devil's Punchbowl Falls walk** (131 m waterfall, about 1 h return, steps).	50 km, 40 min	1 h 30
11:20	**Otira Viaduct Lookout**. A great view of the mountain pass and its engineering, and kea are often here. *Don't feed them, and keep the car doors shut, because kea chew rubber seals.*	10 km, 10 min	15 min
12:45	**Hokitika**. Lunch and fuel. *Optional:* the National Kiwi Centre (kiwi and giant eels, about 45 min) if you prefer it to the gorge.	90 km, 1 h 10	45 min
14:05	**Hokitika Gorge**. Turquoise river and swing bridge, a 30 to 45 min loop walk. **Latest leave from Hokitika is 14:30.** If you are later than that, skip the gorge.	33 km, 35 min	45 min
16:50	**Lake Mapourika** lookout and jetty area (10 min stop, a reflection lake 9 km before Franz Josef).	155 km, 2 h 00	10 min

17:15 to 17:30	Arrive in **Franz Josef**. Fill up with fuel this evening or tomorrow.	10 km, 10 min	n/a

Buffer: about 2 h 45 before sunset. **Driver note:** this is the longest day, with 4 breaks of at least 15 min. SH73 is steep and winding between Arthur's Pass and Otira (16% grade). Use low gear going down. **Sandflies** are active on the whole West Coast, so carry insect repellent from today.

Overnight (2 nights): Franz Josef. There is no Accor hotel here; see Section 5.

Day 3: Mon 8 Mar. Glacier day (Franz Josef and Fox)

about 90 km | about 1 h 30 driving | Sunset 20:15 | Built-in weather buffer

Time	Plan	Walk length
07:45	*Optional, weather-dependent:* a **helicopter scenic flight with a snow landing** on Franz Josef or Fox Glacier (about 20 to 45 min). Mornings are usually clearest. It isn't a boat, but if the seasick traveller is also prone to motion sickness in small aircraft, skip it. The ground-level glacier views below still fill the day.	n/a
08:30	**Franz Josef Glacier / Kā Roimata o Hine Hukatere valley walk** (car park 5 km from the village). Through the river valley to the glacier viewpoint. Add **Sentinel Rock** (20 min return) and **Peters Pool** (10 min, a mountain reflection pool).	about 1 h 30 return, plus 30 min
11:00	**West Coast Wildlife Centre** (in the village). Rowi and Haast tokoeka, the world's rarest kiwi, in a hatchery. Lunch in the village afterwards.	about 1 h
13:30	Drive to Fox Glacier township (23 km, 25 min). Fuel at Fox if not done.	n/a
14:15	**Fox Glacier South Side Walkway** (car park 2 km south of town, across Fox River bridge). Rainforest track to glacier viewpoints. Turn back at the first viewpoint (about 40 min each way) or continue on the full route (about 2 h return, 6.4 km).	1 h 20 to 2 h
16:30	**Lake Matheson / Te Ara Kairaumati** (6 km west of Fox). The famous mirror reflections of Aoraki/Mt Cook and Mt Tasman. Calm late-afternoon and early-morning air gives the best reflections. Walk to Reflection Island and the View of Views.	about 1 h 30 loop
18:15	Café at Lake Matheson (optional), then drive back to Franz Josef (30 km, 35 min).	n/a
18:50	Parked in Franz Josef. *Optional:* Glacier Hot Pools (a rainforest hot-pool complex in the village, on foot).	n/a

Weather plan: if the mountains are hidden all day, swap things around. Do the Wildlife Centre and hot pools today, and Lake Matheson early on Day 4 (see Day 4 option). **Buffer:** about 1 h 30 of loose time spread through the day.

Day 4: Tue 9 Mar. Franz Josef to Wānaka over Haast Pass

about 300 km | about 4 h 00 driving | Sunset 20:18 at Wānaka

Time	Stop	Drive to here	Time there
07:40	Depart Franz Josef (sunrise 07:28). **Fill the tank completely** in Franz Josef or Fox. Fuel is sparse until Wānaka; Haast has a station but don't rely on it being open.	n/a	n/a
(08:10)	*Day 3 weather backup only:* Lake Matheson at dawn, 1 h 30. This pushes every time below back by about 1 h 45, so you would drop Mt Iron.	30 km	1 h 30
09:20	**Knights Point Lookout**. A clifftop view along the wild coastline from the car park. Fur seals are sometimes on the rocks below.	118 km, 1 h 40 (via Fox)	15 min
10:00	Haast. Toilets and fuel top-up if open.	26 km, 20 min	15 min

10:40	**Roaring Billy Falls**. Waterfall across the Haast River.	30 km, 25 min	25 min return
11:30	**Thunder Creek Falls** (28 m), then **Fantail Falls**. Two waterfalls, 5 to 10 min walks each.	25 km, 20 min	30 min total
12:15	**Gates of Haast bridge** and **Haast Pass summit** (photo stops), then **Blue Pools**. Glacier-blue river pools reached by a forest walk and swing bridges.	20 km, 20 min	about 1 h return
13:30	**Makarora**. Late lunch at the café.	8 km, 10 min	40 min
14:50	**The Neck** lookout. Lake Wānaka on one side and Lake Hāwea on the other. Plus the Lake Hāwea lookout pull-offs.	40 km, 35 min	20 min
15:40	Check in at Wānaka.	25 km, 25 min	n/a
16:15 to 17:45	**Mt Iron**. A short climb to a 360° lookout over Wānaka, the lakes and the Southern Alps (2 km from town).	local	about 1 h 30 loop
18:15	**That Wānaka Tree**, the willow standing in the lake, seen from the lakeside path at Roys Bay in the golden-hour light. Walk there along the lakefront from town, or park nearby by 19:00.	local	30 min

Overnight: Grand Mercure Oakridge Resort Lake Wānaka (Accor). **Buffer:** 1 h 15 at the end of the day, and Mt Iron can be shortened or dropped.

Day 5: Wed 10 Mar. Wānaka to Lake Tekapo via Aoraki/Mt Cook

331 km | about 4 h 15 driving | Sunset 20:11 at Tekapo | Stargazing night

Time	Stop	Drive to here	Time there
07:40	Depart Wānaka (sunrise 07:32) via SH6 and SH8A to Tarras, then SH8 north. **Fuel up in Wānaka**; there is no reliable fuel at Mt Cook Village.	n/a	n/a
08:40	**Lindis Pass summit lookout**. Tussock mountain landscape.	80 km, 1 h 00	10 min
09:45	Twizel. Coffee and toilets.	70 km, 55 min	20 min
10:20	**Peter's Lookout** on SH80. The classic view up Lake Pukaki to Aoraki/Mt Cook. Also stop at the Lake Pukaki pull-offs along SH80.	20 km, 15 min	15 min
11:15 to 13:00	**White Horse Hill car park**. Choose *one* walk: (a) **Hooker Valley Track to the second swing bridge and back** (about 1 h 30 to 2 h). *The full track to Hooker Lake is about 3 h return, over your limit.* (b) **Kea Point**. Views of Mt Sefton, Aoraki and the Mueller Glacier moraine lake (about 1 h return).	50 km, 40 min	up to 2 h
13:10	Lunch at Mt Cook Village (the Hermitage or the Old Mountaineers' Café). Visit the Sir Edmund Hillary Alpine Centre or the DOC visitor centre.	3 km	1 h
14:20	**Tasman Glacier View** (Tasman Valley Road, 8 km). Steps up to a view of the Tasman Glacier's terminal lake and icebergs, plus the **Blue Lakes**.	8 km, 15 min	about 45 min
15:20	Depart for Tekapo. Optional photo stops at the Lake Pukaki visitor centre lookout and the salmon farm shop.	n/a	n/a
16:50	**Church of the Good Shepherd** and the **sheepdog statue** on the shore of Lake Tekapo.	105 km, 1 h 20	30 min
17:20	Check in. Early dinner.	local	n/a

about 21:00 to 23:30	**Stargazing** with the Dark Sky Project summit experience. The operator's coach takes you up Mt John from its Tekapo base, so **you don't drive**. The new moon is around 8 March, so the sky will be very dark and the Milky Way at its best. If the tour is full or cloudy, stargaze for free from the lakefront near the church (on foot from the hotel).	on foot or by coach	2 to 2.5 h

Weather plan: if Aoraki is in cloud this morning, go straight to Tekapo and do Mt Cook tomorrow morning instead (see Section 6, B2). **Overnight:** Peppers Bluewater Resort, Lake Tekapo (Accor).

Day 6: Thu 11 Mar. Lake Tekapo to Queenstown

about 295 km | about 3 h 45 driving | Sunset 20:17 at Queenstown

Time	Stop	Drive to here	Time there
08:00	**Mt John summit** (the road is gated and tolled; check opening time). A 360° view of Lake Tekapo and the Mackenzie Basin. Coffee at Astro Café. The short summit circuit is optional (30 to 40 min).	8 km, 15 min	1 h
09:30	Depart Tekapo. Fuel in Tekapo or Twizel.	n/a	n/a
10:45	**Clay Cliffs** near Omarama. Eroded gravel pinnacles. The last part is an unsealed road, and there is a small honesty-box fee. Walk about 30 min.	95 km, 1 h 15	45 min
11:40	Omarama. Quick lunch.	10 km, 10 min	35 min
13:40	Over the Lindis Pass to **Cromwell**. Lake Dunstan lookout.	115 km, 1 h 25	15 min
14:25	**Kawarau Gorge**. The Roaring Meg lookout, and the Kawarau Bridge where you can watch bungy jumpers for free.	40 km, 30 min	30 min
15:20	Arrive Queenstown and check in (park the car). **The car stays parked from here.**	25 km, 25 min	n/a
15:45 to 16:45	**Kiwi Park Queenstown** (Brecon Street). Kiwi in the nocturnal house, plus a conservation show. *Check last entry time; if it is too early, move Kiwi Park to Day 8 in place of the Crown Range.*	on foot or 5 min	1 h
17:00 to 18:30	**Skyline Gondola** (next to Kiwi Park). The lookout over Lake Wakatipu, The Remarkables and Coronet Peak. Dinner at the top is optional.	on foot	1 h 30

Overnight: Queenstown, Accor (Mercure Queenstown Resort or Novotel Queenstown Lakeside; see Section 5). **Buffer:** 1 h 45 before sunset, and the afternoon is all on foot.

Day 7: Fri 12 Mar. Milford Sound by road, ending in Te Anau

412 km | about 5 h 45 driving | Sunset 20:18 at Milford, 20:19 at Te Anau | No boat

Time	Stop	Drive to here	Time there
07:45	Depart Queenstown (sunrise 07:37) along Lake Wakatipu. Pack for one night only; the main bags can stay in the car.	n/a	n/a
08:10	**Devil's Staircase lookout** over Lake Wakatipu.	30 km, 25 min	10 min
10:00	**Te Anau**. Coffee, toilets, and **fill the tank**. This is the last dependable fuel; there is no fuel along the Milford Road, and Milford's own supply is limited. Pick up a picnic lunch.	140 km, 1 h 40	30 min

11:15	Eglinton Valley flats, then **Mirror Lakes** (reflections of the Earl Mountains; 10 min boardwalk).	58 km, 45 min	20 min
11:50	**Lake Gunn Nature Walk**. Beech forest down to the lake.	20 km, 15 min	45 min loop
12:55	**Monkey Creek**, where kea are often seen (don't feed them), then **Hollyford valley views**. Join the queue at the **Homer Tunnel** traffic lights (waits of up to 15 min).	20 km, 20 min	15 min, plus the tunnel wait
13:45	**The Chasm**. The river carves through sculpted rock (20 min loop). *Check DOC for status; part of the track has been closed in the past.*	15 km, 20 min	20 min
14:20 to 15:40	**Milford Sound / Piopiotahi**. Picnic lunch and the **Foreshore Walk** (20 to 30 min) for the classic Mitre Peak view and the waterfalls. Watch the fiord from land; no cruise.	10 km, 15 min	1 h 20
15:40	Depart Milford. **Latest leave time is 16:30.** Stop again anywhere that was busy on the way in (the light is different in the afternoon).	n/a	n/a
17:50	Arrive in **Te Anau** and check in.	120 km, 1 h 50 + stops	n/a
18:00 to 18:45	**Punanga Manu o Te Anau Bird Sanctuary** (lakeside, a short walk from town, free). **Takahē**, once thought extinct, plus kākā and other native birds.	on foot or 2 km	45 min

Important: there is **no mobile coverage** for most of the Milford Road. Download offline maps the night before. Check the **Milford Road status** (NZTA / milfordroad.co.nz) before leaving Queenstown, because heavy rain can close it at short notice. **Sandflies** at Milford are intense, so wear repellent and long sleeves. **Overnight:** Te Anau (there is no Accor hotel here; see Section 5).

Day 8: Sat 13 Mar. Te Anau to Queenstown: Glenorchy road, Arrowtown and the Crown Range

about 335 km | about 4 h 45 driving | Sunset 20:13 at Queenstown

Time	Stop	Drive to here	Time there
07:50	Depart Te Anau (sunrise 07:41). If the takahē visit was missed on Day 7, go at 07:45 instead and leave at 08:30.	n/a	n/a
09:50	Arrive in Queenstown, then carry straight on along the Glenorchy road.	170 km, 2 h 00	n/a
10:20	**Bennett's Bluff Lookout**. One of the best lake and mountain views in the region, over Lake Wakatipu toward Mt Earnslaw.	30 km, 30 min	15 min
11:00 to 12:30	**Glenorchy**. The red wharf shed (lakeside photo spot) and the **Glenorchy Lagoon Walkway** (boardwalks, birdlife and mountain reflections, about 1 h). Lunch in the village.	16 km, 15 min	1 h 30
13:15	Back toward Queenstown. Stop at **Wilson Bay / Moke Lake turn-off views** if wanted.	46 km, 45 min	n/a
14:00 to 15:30	**Arrowtown**. A gold-rush main street and the **Chinese Settlement** (short historic trail by the Arrow River).	22 km, 25 min	1 h 30
15:55	**Crown Range Road lookouts** (zig-zag lookout and the summit). A sweeping view over the Wakatipu Basin. Turn back at the summit.	18 km, 25 min	30 min
16:50	Refuel at Frankton (beside the airport) so the car is full for return in the morning. The rental is most likely full-to-full; check the contract.	30 km, 30 min	10 min

17:15	Check in at the hotel. Repack for the flight. Free evening in town on foot.	10 km, 15 min	n/a

Buffer: about 3 h before sunset. Drop the Crown Range or Arrowtown if the morning ran late. **Overnight:** Queenstown, Accor (book the same hotel as Day 6 if you were happy with it).

Day 9: Sun 14 Mar. Return car and fly (no sightseeing)

Time	Plan
07:00	Breakfast. Check out by 07:45.
07:50	Drive to Queenstown Airport (about 10 km, 15 min). The car is already refuelled from last night; if not, use Frankton (2 min from the airport).
08:15 to 08:30	Return the car to the rental desk or car park at ZQN. Do the walk-around with staff and photograph the fuel gauge and odometer.
08:30 to 09:00	Check in and drop bags. For a flight to Australia, airlines close check-in about 60 min before departure, so you are well ahead.
11:00	Flight departs.

Buffer: about 2 h 30 at the airport. This is deliberate, because ZQN is small and queues can be long on Sunday mornings.

5. Accommodation plan (8 nights, 2 beds per room)

Night	Date	Town	First choice	Accor?	Fallbacks if over NZ$300 or full
1	Sat 6 Mar	Christchurch	Novotel Christchurch Airport	Yes	ibis Christchurch or Novotel Christchurch Cathedral Square (both Accor, in the city, 20 min further from the Day 2 route)
2 and 3	Sun 7 to Tue 9 Mar	Franz Josef	Scenic Hotel Franz Josef Glacier	No (none in town)	Rainforest Retreat (motel and lodge rooms); Glacier View Motel; Legacy Te Waonui (very nice, but likely over budget)
4	Tue 9 Mar	Wānaka	Grand Mercure Oakridge Resort Lake Wānaka (standard rooms can have 2 twin beds)	Yes	Edgewater Wānaka or a Wānaka motel (non-Accor)
5	Wed 10 Mar	Lake Tekapo	Peppers Bluewater Resort	Yes	Mantra Lake Tekapo (listed under Accor; check); Lake Tekapo Motels and Holiday Park (non-Accor)
6	Thu 11 Mar	Queenstown	Mercure Queenstown Resort (on-site parking) or Novotel Queenstown Lakeside (central, parking costs extra)	Yes	Other Accor in Queenstown (Sofitel, Grand Mercure Hotel St Moritz) are usually over NZ$300
7	Fri 12 Mar	Te Anau	Distinction Luxmore Hotel Te Anau	No (none in town)	Kingsgate Hotel Te Anau; Te Anau Lakeview Holiday Park (motel units)
8	Sat 13 Mar	Queenstown	Same hotel as Night 6	Yes	As Night 6

Budget check: I could not confirm March 2027 rates. Tekapo, Queenstown and Wānaka are the most likely to go over NZ$300 for a 2-bed room. Check member rates in the ALL app first; a member rate or an Accor Plus rate often brings these under the limit. Choose free-cancellation rates now and recheck prices in January, then rebook if they drop. **When booking, choose a room type that explicitly says "2 single beds", "twin" or "2 queen beds".** If the listing says "1 king or 2 twin beds", add a booking note (template in Section 8). All hotels on this list have parking; confirm the cost when booking.

6. Backup plans

#	If this happens	Do this
B1	SH73 Arthur's Pass is closed on Day 2 (slips or crashes)	Go via Lewis Pass (SH7) to Greymouth, about 345 km. Sleep in **Hokitika or Greymouth**, because carrying on to Franz Josef would go over 500 km. On Day 3, drive 135 km to Franz Josef early and do the glacier walks and Lake Matheson. Shorten Day 4's Mt Iron if needed. Cancel night 2 in Franz Josef (check the cancellation terms when booking).
B2	Aoraki/Mt Cook is in cloud on Day 5	Drive Wānaka to Twizel to Tekapo directly (about 230 km). On Day 6, go Tekapo to Mt Cook Village (105 km) for the walks in the morning, then Mt Cook to Queenstown (about 265 km). That's 370 km in total, which is fine, but skip the Clay Cliffs, Kiwi Park and Gondola that day (do Kiwi Park on Day 8 instead).
B3	The Milford Road is closed, or it's a downpour, on Day 7	Swap the days. Day 7 becomes Queenstown to Te Anau via the Glenorchy road and Arrowtown is done on Day 8. On Day 8, do Te Anau to Milford to Te Anau to Queenstown (120 + 120 + 170 = 410 km, start at 07:45). If the road is still closed, spend Day 8 at the Te Anau bird sanctuary and lakefront, and on the Queenstown sights.

B4	Haast Pass (SH6) is closed on Day 4	Stay another night in Franz Josef or Fox and enjoy the wildlife centre and hot pools. The next day, drive Franz Josef to Wānaka to Twizel (about 450 km) and go to Tekapo or Twizel, and see Mt Cook on Day 6 (as in B2). Ask hotels about flexible dates when booking.
B5	The glacier helicopter flight is cancelled	Book with the operator's weather-cancellation full refund. Try again early on Day 4 from Fox before you leave, but only if it is clear by 08:00.
B6	The driver is tired or unwell	No day needs more than 6 h of driving. The 2 longest days have marked "skip" stops (Hokitika Gorge, Lake Gunn, The Chasm). Never push on toward sunset; you can stop overnight in Hokitika, Haast, Twizel or Te Anau.

7. Optional extras for spare time (all within your rules)

- **Wildlife:** the National Kiwi Centre in Hokitika (Day 2), Glacier Hot Pools in Franz Josef (Day 3), the Lake Pukaki salmon farm shop (Day 5), and kea anywhere in the alps.
- **Lookouts:** Lake Hāwea's main lookout (Day 4) and the Moke Lake road (Day 8). The Ladies Mile lookouts above Queenstown are a short drive from the hotel on the evening of Day 6 or Day 8, if back by 19:30.
- **Not suitable:** Shotover Jet, TSS Earnslaw, Doubtful or Milford Sound cruises, Te Anau glowworm caves (all boats). Roys Peak, Ben Lomond, Key Summit and the full Hooker Valley Track (all over 2 h). Hokitika beach and Gillespies Beach (beaches).

Recommendations

8. Booking timeline (today is 9 November 2026; departure is in about 17 weeks)

Book by	What	Why now	Notes
This week (by 15 Nov 2026)	**One-way rental car**, collected at CHC Airport on 6 Mar from 15:30 and returned at ZQN Airport on 14 Mar at 08:15	March is busy, and one-way cars are limited. One-way fees vary a lot (often NZ$0 to 200+), so compare.	A compact or mid-size car is fine (all roads are sealed except the Clay Cliffs gravel section; check the rental terms for unsealed roads). Use 1 driver, with an Australian licence in English that is current and carried at all times. Add excess cover. Make sure the return time at ZQN is 08:15 on 14 Mar.
This week	**All 8 nights of accommodation** (Section 5)	The best-value twin rooms in Tekapo, Franz Josef and Queenstown sell out first.	Choose free-cancellation rates. Book through the ALL app or website for Accor points and member rates.
By 30 Nov 2026	**Dark Sky Project stargazing**, Tekapo, Wed 10 Mar, a late session (about 21:00 or later)	Popular, and near the new moon is peak season.	Check the cancellation-for-cloud policy. If you have a choice, avoid the earliest session, because the sky isn't fully dark until about 21:00.
By mid-January 2027	*Optional* glacier helicopter flight with snow landing, Mon 8 Mar about 08:00	Not essential to book early; morning slots fill in high season.	Only with a full refund for weather. Confirm the traveller who gets seasick is happy flying in a small helicopter.
By mid-January 2027	Recheck hotel prices	Rates often drop; rebook if cheaper.	Keep a list of booking reference numbers (template below).
Up to 1 week before	Skyline Gondola, Kiwi Park Queenstown, Willowbank	Usually fine to buy on the day, but online is often cheaper.	Check Willowbank's March closing time (Day 1 depends on it).
48 h before departure	Road and track checks	Things change fast in the mountains.	NZTA Waka Kotahi road status for SH73, SH6 Haast Pass and SH94 Milford Road; DOC track alerts for Hooker Valley, Fox South Side, The Chasm and Blue Pools; MetService mountain forecasts.
Within 24 h before landing	NZ arrival declaration (NZ Traveller Declaration)	Speeds up arrival at CHC.	Declare food and outdoor gear (boots must be clean).

9. Copy-paste templates

a) Rental car request

```
One-way rental: Christchurch Airport (CHC) -> Queenstown Airport (ZQN)
Pick-up:  Sat 6 Mar 2027, 15:30 (flight lands 14:30, may be delayed by customs)
Drop-off: Sun 14 Mar 2027, 08:15
Driver: 1 (full Australian licence, in English)
Car: compact/mid-size automatic, 2 adults + 2 large suitcases
Extras: excess reduction cover; no extra driver needed
Please confirm: one-way fee, fuel policy (full-to-full?), any restriction on
the Milford Road (SH94) or short unsealed roads (Clay Cliffs, Omarama).
```

b) Hotel booking note (paste into "special requests")

```
Two adults travelling together – we need a room with TWO SEPARATE BEDS
(twin / 2 singles / 2 queens), please, not one king.
We are self-driving and will arrive by car around [time]; please confirm parking.
ALL member number: [your number]
```

c) Booking tracker (fill in as you book)

Item	Date	Provider	Ref no.	Cost (NZ$)	Free cancel until	Twin beds confirmed?
Rental car	6 to 14 Mar					n/a
Night 1 Christchurch	6 Mar					
Nights 2 and 3 Franz Josef	7 to 8 Mar					
Night 4 Wānaka	9 Mar					
Night 5 Tekapo	10 Mar					
Night 6 Queenstown	11 Mar					
Night 7 Te Anau	12 Mar					
Night 8 Queenstown	13 Mar					
Dark Sky Project	10 Mar					n/a
Heli flight (optional)	8 Mar					n/a

d) Each morning's 2-minute check

```
[ ] Sunset today: ____  -> latest parked time: sunset minus 60 min = ____
[ ] Road status for today's highways (NZTA map)   [ ] Weather (MetService)
[ ] Fuel: at least half a tank + next fuel stop identified
[ ] Offline map downloaded (essential on Day 7 and Day 4)
[ ] Water, snacks, insect repellent, rain jacket, sunscreen
```

10. Driving tips for New Zealand (useful for an Australian driver)

- NZ also drives on the **left**, and the road rules are very similar. Main differences: **one-lane bridges** (a red, smaller arrow means give way), frequent passing lanes, and no motorway-style roads outside cities.
- Open-road limits are 100 km/h, but many alpine and West Coast roads are realistically 70 to 80 km/h, so the drive times above include this. Watch for cyclists on Arthur's Pass and the Crown Range.
- The **NZ sun is strong** (high UV), even on cool days, so wear sunscreen and sunglasses.
- **Fuel stops to note:** Hokitika or Franz Josef (Day 2), Franz Josef or Fox (Day 4, before Haast Pass), Wānaka (Day 5), Tekapo or Twizel (Day 6), and Te Anau (Day 7, before the Milford Road).
- **Kea:** they are entertaining but damage cars. Don't feed them, and don't leave anything loose on the roof rack or wipers.
- **Sandflies:** they bite on the West Coast and at Milford. Bring an insect repellent with DEET or picaridin.
- Pack layers. Early March is late summer: typically 15 to 24 °C by day in the lakes area and colder at the mountain lookouts and Mt John at night (bring a warm jacket for stargazing).

11. Assumptions I made (you did not specify these)

- **Rental type:** an ordinary car rather than a campervan (you asked for hotels). An automatic, in the compact or mid-size class.
- **Entry to NZ:** passports, visa or NZeTA status, and travel insurance are outside this plan's scope (you asked for the driving part only). I assume they are handled. Your 11:00 departure from ZQN is treated as a flight to Australia (international, so check-in closes about 60 min before).

- **Helicopter flights** are not boats, so one is offered as an optional extra. Skip it if motion sickness is a concern.
- **Meals:** casual cafés and picnic lunches on the long driving days. No restaurant bookings are planned. Book one dinner in Queenstown for Day 8 if you would like a nicer last night.
- **Prices, opening hours and track status** were not all confirmed for March 2027. Where I could not verify them, the plan says "check". Distances and times are estimates, and the sunrise and sunset times are calculated values (accurate to within about 2 minutes).

12. Next steps

1. Book the one-way rental car this week with template 9a.
2. Book the 8 nights with free cancellation, starting with Tekapo, Franz Josef and Queenstown. Use template 9b for twin beds.
3. Book Dark Sky Project for 10 March by the end of November.
4. In January: recheck hotel prices, and decide about the glacier flight.
5. The week before: check Willowbank's hours, the DOC track alerts and the NZTA road status. Download offline maps.

This plan does not book, reserve or contact any provider. All bookings are for you to make.